PHIL1001: Week 07 Workshop Exercise: A close read of Aristotle

Selection from: Aristotle (1984), *Nicomachean Ethics*, translated by W.D. Ross in Jonathan Barnes, ed., *The Complete Words of Aristotle*, Vol.2, Princeton: Princeton University Press: 1729-1867.

Context:

In the pages leading up to the following passage, Aristotle had been seeking an answer to the question "What is the chief good"? The answer he arrives is "happiness" (although a better translation of would be "living well".) But this, he realizes, is just the start of an answer. The next task is to say what living well consists in for human beings. That's where this passage picks up.

better translation: "living well"

The question-->

Step 1

Step 2

The next question--->

Toward an answer----->

Step 3

Putting together Step 1 & Step 2.

Presumably, however, to say that happiness is the chief good seems a platitude, and a clearer account of what it is is still desired. This might perhaps be given, if we could first ascertain the function of man. For just as for a flute-player, a sculptor, or any artist, and, in general, for all things that have a function or activity, the good and the 'well' is thought to reside in the function, so would it seem to be for man, if he has a function. Have the carpenter, then, and the tanner certain functions or activities, and has man none? Is he naturally functionless? Or as eye, hand, foot, and in general each of the parts evidently has a function, may one lay it down that man similarly has a function apart from all these? What then can this be? Life seems to be common even to plants, but we are seeking what is peculiar to man. Let us exclude, therefore, the life of nutrition and growth. Next there would be a life of perception, but *it* also seems to be common even to the horse, the ox, and every animal. There remains, then, an active life of the element that has a rational principle (of this, one part has such a principle in the sense of being obedient to one, the other in the sense of possessing one and exercising thought); and as this too can be taken in two ways, we must state that life in the sense of activity is what we mean; for this seems to be the more proper sense of the term. Now if the function of man is an activity of soul in accordance with, or not without, rational principle, and if we say a so-and-so and a good so-and-so have a function which is the same in kind, e.g. a lyre-player and a good lyre-player, and so without qualification in all cases, eminence in respect of excellence being added to the function (for the function of a lyre-player is to play the lyre, and that of a good lyre-player is to do so well): if this is the case, [and we state the function of man to be a certain kind of life, and this to be an activity or actions of the soul implying a rational principle, and the function of a good man to be the good and noble performance of these, and if any action is well performed when it is performed in accordance with the appropriate excellence: if this is the case,] human good turns out to be activity of soul in conformity with excellence, and if there are more than one excellence, in conformity with the best and most complete.

* This paragraph is one long sentence! It is both ugly and difficult to follow! Don't imitate this in your own writing!

The exercise: *There's a pretty simple (and influential!) argument hiding in this passage, but it's not easy to find! Let's read the passage together as a whole workshop group and pause at each step to try to work out what Aristotle's point or argument is for that step.*